The 2025 examination produced near-identical averages across all three sections — 5.4, 5.4 and 5.5 out of 10 — with very few students at either extreme. The middle is crowded; the marks that separate a 5 from an 8 come from the specific skills assessors described, not from writing more.

Section	Average /10	What it was
A	5.4	Analytical response to a text
B	5.4	Creating a text (Frameworks of Ideas)
C	5.5	Analysis of argument and language

How assessors marked

- **Holistic, criteria-based, benchmarked.** Every section was assessed against the published criteria and expected qualities (EQs), using benchmark scripts to set standards. The three EQs are interconnected: the quality of your ideas (EQ1) sets the level of challenge for structuring and substantiating them (EQ2), and language (EQ3) is judged by how well it communicates those ideas.
- **Everything is applied in relation to the topic.** Sound ideas, apt quotations or fluent expression that do not serve the set task cannot score highly. This principle recurs through every section of the report.
- **First-draft conditions were respected.** Assessors explicitly acknowledged that exam writing is timed first-draft work; fluency was not equated with perfection.

Administrative habits that mattered

- Shade the box for your chosen text *and* topic in Section A, and for your Framework *and* stimulus in Section B — and write the Section B title at the start of your response.
- Choose the topic that *best* lets you demonstrate your knowledge and skills, not the one you predicted.
- Bring a dictionary. Assessors specifically noted students with no strategy for unfamiliar words in topics — some simply substituted "and" for a term they didn't understand, which derailed

their essays.

The 2025 topics were deliberately narrow — specified ideas and values rather than broad prompts — and this shaped how responses needed to be structured, sequenced and evidenced. Students with topic-interpretation strategies handled both familiar and unfamiliar phrasings well.

Topic types

- **Propositional topics** offered a proposition with a command term: *Discuss*, *Do you agree?* or *To what extent do you agree?* You may challenge the proposition where warranted, but never the topic's conceptual focus itself — a topic linking love and destruction requires discussing both, though "inseparable" can be contested.
- **Quotation topics** paired a quotation with a proposition. There was no obligatory way to use the quotation, but how you used it revealed your understanding of what it conveys in context.

The verbs

The verb in a topic carries the author's purpose, and flattening every verb into a generic "presents" was unwise. Assessors also warned that verbs are often nominalised or implied, and new ones appear each year.

Used in 2025	New in 2025
celebrates, challenges, condemns, demonstrates, displays, explores, highlights, mocks, shows, suggests	is (a cry for), depicts, glorifies, warns

Implications: where the top marks lived

There was a direct correlation between recognising a topic's implications and higher scores. Watch for: absolute terms ("there are *no* right choices"), connotation ("*easy to overlook*"),

what a proposition is silent about, comparison ("requires *more than* individual effort"), an included quotation, and the verb itself.

What high-scoring responses did

- **Interpreted before writing** — considered what the topic implies, not just what it states.
- **Sequenced strategically** — used opening and closing summary sentences in each paragraph to make ideas and their connections explicit, guiding the reader through the reading of the text.
- **Substantiated with range** — drew on linguistic elements, characters, structure, plot and allusion, and discussed how these interplayed; assessors noted high scorers took "a more philosophic consideration of the ideas, rather than a literal consideration".
- **Resolved the topic** — used the conclusion to actually answer the question, showing the interplay of context, audience and purpose.
- **Used language to communicate.** Sophisticated vocabulary scored only when it carried sophisticated ideas; "poorly applied polysyllabic words" were called out explicitly.

What limited responses

- Discussing a favourite theme adjacent to the topic instead of the topic (e.g. writing about patriarchy when the topic was about truth).
- Addressing only half the topic — in a topic such as "individuals can be both victims and villains", writing about villainy but not victimhood.
- Substituting prepared material for the terms actually on the paper, or having no strategy for unfamiliar words.

Nearly half the state wrote on protest, yet all four Frameworks averaged within 0.4 marks of each other — choose the Framework that suits your ideas, not the popular one.

Framework	% of students	Average score /20
Writing about country	10%	11.2
Writing about protest	47%	10.9

Framework	% of students	Average score /20
Writing about personal journeys	25%	10.9
Writing about play	17%	10.8

The rules of the task

- **The title is fixed.** You cannot change or modify it; assessors ignored any additions. Choosing a title selects its Framework — no mixing and matching titles, Frameworks or stimulus sets. If your shaded box and your title disagreed, assessors followed the title.
- **Write the title at the start** and shade both the Framework and stimulus boxes.
- **Stimulus ideas must come from your selected Framework's** stimulus material, though how you use them is open.
- **Mentor texts don't need referencing**, and there is no preferred form, style, purpose or audience — responses could explain, express, reflect or argue, and could adapt or subvert any prose form.

What lifted responses

- Using the title as the focus while exploring Framework ideas purposefully through a cohesive text.
- Making deliberate structural and linguistic choices that amplify ideas — the annotated high scorers moved economically between place and time, used imagery to imply location, and chose words that carried complex emotion.
- Establishing a voice that connects strategically with the reader — one exemplar built "a thoughtful, confiding reflective voice" from its opening lines.
- Trusting an adult reader to infer meaning, and guiding that inference deliberately.

What limited responses

- Using stimulus literally (a story of children playing a board game with no other connection to the Framework or title).
- Rambling texts with no observable purpose; simplistic or barely-related ideas; relying on plot alone.
- Contorting a pre-prepared piece to fit the exam title, or writing for yourself rather than a reader.
- Sensationalised content, cloying sentiment and clichéd language — assessors said these "were rarely the most powerful option". Remember an unknown adult reads this for assessment.

The 2025 text was a letter to a community newsletter from a "local resident" proposing that a regional town replace its annual fireworks with an alternative celebration. Students found it highly accessible — which made the discriminators sharper.

Background information is not decoration

The publication details and the author's "local resident" persona had to be used: inferring the regional audience and its values, the author's altruistic credibility, and the unhurried "evolution, not urgency" framing enabled the most focused analyses. Read the background inferentially *before* writing — the analysis flows from it.

The argument structure most students saw

- Establishing a shared value: love of the celebration in its beautiful setting.
- Raising previously unconsidered problems — environment, frightened pets (with a photo), noise-sensitive residents, cost — aligned with community values.
- Rebutting reasons to keep the status quo.
- Presenting the alternative as a "win-win" (with an inspiring second visual).

What separated skill levels

- **Identification is not analysis.** Most students could list arguments and label techniques; far fewer could explain how the *sequencing* of ideas served the purpose, or what a device actually did to the intended audience.
- **Interplay was the discriminator.** The strongest responses explained how argument, written language and visuals worked together — nearly everyone noticed the frightened dog photo, but skill showed in explaining its contribution to the developing argument, not just "appeals to emotion".
- **Strategic selection beat exhaustive coverage.** Discussing every element was impossible in the time and wasn't expected; choosing the elements most central to the persuasion correlated strongly with success.

Language worth recognising

Assessor-noted elements included appeals to parochial pride, social justice and economic responsibility; strategic characterisation ("beloved pets", "little Fido or Fluffy", "cheaper and smarter"); escalation ("a single wayward spark … devastating consequences"); reflection-prompting rhetorical questions; inspirational collective language ("Together we have the opportunity … to lead the way"); and closing the door on alternatives ("a no-brainer").

The habits below fall straight out of the 2025 report — each one addresses something assessors explicitly rewarded or penalised.

Before the exam

- Build a topic-interpretation routine: identify the conceptual focus, the command term, the verb, and at least two implications before planning.
- Rehearse unfamiliar-verb strategy — and pack a dictionary.
- Practise writing to a fixed title in Section B without bending a pre-prepared piece to fit.
- For Section C practice, always start from the background information and write down audience, purpose and author positioning before analysing.

In the exam

- Shade every box: text and topic (Section A); Framework and stimulus (Section B) — and write the Section B title first.
- Section A: open and close each paragraph with sentences that link your ideas to the topic; use the conclusion to resolve the question.
- Section B: keep the title in view as you write; make every structural and word choice serve your purpose and reader.
- Section C: select the few elements most central to the persuasion and explain their interplay — argument, language and visuals together.
- Everywhere: sophisticated language only where it communicates a sophisticated idea.

Summarised from the VCAA 2025 English examination report. Read alongside the 2024 takeaways and the assessment criteria.